Caribbean Qualitative Research Lab: Student Quick Guide

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Open the Lab from the link on your Moodle course page, learn coding first, then follow steps 1 to 9. Everything stays on your device: no account, no AI, nothing uploaded.

Before you start

- **Open it:** click the Lab link on Moodle (or go to rj952.github.io/CaribbeanQualLab). It opens in a new window and works on a laptop, tablet or phone.
- **Saving:** your work saves automatically in this browser on this device. Another computer, another browser or a private window will not show it.
- **Back up every time:** click **Save backup** (top bar) at the end of every session. Keep the `.cqrl.json` file in your own storage, as your ethics approval requires.
- **Change computers:** on the new computer, click **Open backup** and choose your `.cqrl.json` file.
- **Shared computer?** Save a backup, then use **About & licence → Delete this project from this device** before you leave.

Step 0: Learn coding first (15–20 minutes)

Do this before you code. It teaches the ladder you will climb in your analysis:

Rung	What it is	Question it answers
Quotation	The participant's exact words	What did the participant actually say?
Code	A short label for what one piece of data means	What does this statement mean?
Category	A group of related codes: a topic, no claim	What other statements express related ideas?
Theme	A pattern of shared meaning with one central idea that helps answer your research question	What important pattern does this reveal?

1. Click **Learn coding first** (step 0 in the menu).
2. Work through the five steps: *Four words, four jobs*, *Sort the examples*, *The four questions*, *Do these belong together?* and *Ready to code*.
3. Write your reasons in your own words. Explaining your decision matters more than matching the guide's answer.
4. Compare your answers with a classmate. Different labels can both be right if each of you can explain them.
5. Tick the four checks and click **Finish the lesson and start coding**.

Remember: a theme is not simply a bigger category. "Class size", "workload" and "resources" are codes or categories. A theme makes a claim the evidence must support.

Steps 1–9: from evidence to findings

1. **Set up your study** (*Guide & progress*)
   - Name the project and type your research question(s), context and participants, and positionality.
   - First time? Click **Load practice study** to practise on fictional Caribbean data.
2. **Add your evidence** (*Sources*)
   - Click **Import files** (.txt, .docx or .csv) or **Paste text**.
   - Click **Pseudonymise names…** to replace real names before you code.
   - Use **Participant attributes…** to record details such as Group or Site.
3. **Code** (*Code*)

- Pick a source, select words in the transcript, then click a code or type a new one and press Enter. Keys 1–9 apply your first nine codes.
- Click a highlight to analyse it: *Why does this code fit?*, inference, interpretation, a language note (keep Creole exactly as said) and a memo. Mark contrasting evidence as a negative case.

4. **Organise codes** (*Codebook*)
   - Define each code and say when to use it and when not to. Merge duplicates and group related codes into categories.
5. **Connect the literature** (*Literature*)
   - Add references, or import a RIS file from Zotero, Mendeley or EndNote.
   - Link each reference to an excerpt, code or theme: supports, contradicts, extends or explains.
6. **Build themes** (*Themes & map*)
   - Write each theme's central idea as a claim, not a topic heading. Drag codes onto it and write its narrative.
7. **Triangulate** (*Triangulation*)
   - For each theme, review the evidence by source type and write your triangulated interpretation.
8. **Write up** (*Write-up*)
   - For each theme: the claim, your best quotations, the literature, alternative explanations, and the finding.
9. **Export** (*Export*)
   - Download the **Word** report, then click **Save backup**.

Throughout, keep reflexive notes in the *Journal*. The Lab records your coding decisions automatically in the decision trail. Use *Retrieve & matrix* to search the data and compare groups.

What to submit and getting help

- **Submit** what your lecturer asks for on Moodle: usually the Word report from *Export*, and your `.cqrl.json` backup so your lecturer can see your reasoning.
- **Stuck on coding?** Go back to *Learn coding first*. If you cannot explain why two codes belong together, ask your lecturer before you build themes.

- **Lost work?** Open your latest backup with **Open backup**. Work saved only in a browser can be lost if its data is cleared.
- **PDF transcripts:** copy the text into **Paste text**, or save the file as .txt or .docx first.

Caribbean Qualitative Research Lab, created by Dr. Rohan Jowallah. Free and open source (GNU AGPL-3.0).